

A LESSON WITH JOE HENDERSON

FROM DIGGING DEEPER VIDEO #100

In his song Isotope, Joe Henderson comes up with a very cool set of chord substitutions to the typical "I - VI - II - V" progression. Instead of that typical turnaround progression, he finds another way to "start on the root, and end on the root," which is the whole point of the turnaround progression.

The melody he puts over the chords is also very interesting. His chords have a diminished relationship (minor 3rds) to each other, so the melody ends up coming from the diminished scale as well. Great chords, and a great lick too!

#1 - The Harmonic Problem to be Solved

A musical staff in treble clef with a key signature of one sharp (F#). It shows a sequence of five measures. The first and fifth measures are labeled C⁷ and I. The three middle measures are labeled with three question marks (???) and are marked with a double bar line between the first and second of these measures. Each measure contains a single eighth note, represented by a diagonal slash.

Starting on a C chord, ending on a C chord, and three stops in between.

#2 - Typical "Turnaround Progression"

A musical staff in treble clef with a key signature of one sharp (F#). It shows a sequence of five measures. The first and fifth measures are labeled C⁷ and I. The second measure is labeled A^m⁷ and vi. The third measure is labeled D^m⁷ and ii. The fourth measure is labeled G⁷ and V. Each measure contains a single eighth note, represented by a diagonal slash.

Using the Circle of 4th to get us back to C (A to D to G to C).

#3 - Joe's Harmonic Solution

A musical staff in treble clef with a key signature of one sharp (F#). It shows a sequence of five measures. The first and fifth measures are labeled C⁷ and I. The second measure is labeled A⁷ and VI. The third measure is labeled F#⁷ and #IV. The fourth measure is labeled E^b⁷ and bIII. Each measure contains a single eighth note, represented by a diagonal slash.

Joe realized there is the perfect amount of space to use min. 3rds.

#4 - Joe's Melody

A musical staff in treble clef with a key signature of one sharp (F#). It shows a sequence of five measures. The first and fifth measures are labeled C⁷ and I. The second measure is labeled A⁷ and VI. The third measure is labeled F#⁷ and #IV. The fourth measure is labeled E^b⁷ and bIII. Each measure contains a single eighth note, represented by a diagonal slash.

He uses just chord tones to create a great, memorable melody.